From Big Tickets to €5 Starts: Investing Opens to First-Timers

upvance

Area: Customers & Market TREND

Fractional shares, automatic savings plans and card round-ups let people start investing with a few euros, removing the price barrier. Fractions made up more than 10% of all share transactions reported in the EU in 2023-2024 (ESMA, 2025).

FORCES

- Fractions remove the share-price barrier
- Automatic plans replace the buy decision
- Lack of money is the top barrier
- Neobrokers compete for young first-time investors
- Strained public pensions push private saving

VALUES

- Starting small over starting ready
- Automatic habit over one big decision
- A piece of a share over none
- Plain disclosure over friendly labels
- A small first step over confidence first

PHASE

Strengthening

Fractions were 10%+ of EU reported share transactions (2023-24), yet round-ups stay small and EU rules on fractions are inconsistent.

EXAMPLES

- Trade Republic (Dec 2025): 10+ million customers in 18 countries, 70% investing for the first time.
- KBC (Jan 2025): about 350,000 clients in Belgium and Czechia invest spare change from card payments.
- Swedbank Estonia (Oct 2025): 19,000 clients joined round-ups in nine months; 39% were new investors.
- Revolut Romania (2026): whole or fractional US and EU stocks from €1.
- XTB (Apr 2023) brought fractional shares to Romania with a €10 minimum order.
- BlackRock survey (14 European markets, 2024): 65% of non-investors say they don't have enough money.

INNOVATORS

- Christian Hecker, Trade Republic co-founder
- KBC Asset Management built spare-change investing
- Swedbank brought round-ups to Estonia
- XTB and Revolut bring fractions to Romania
- ESMA sets disclosure rules for fractions

IMPACT

- ▲ Round-ups turn the first investment into a background habit, so people start without a separate buy decision.
- ▼ Tiny accounts stay at a few euros and never grow into regular saving; there is no data yet on balances after year one.
- Simple wording like 'a piece of a share' helps starters, but derivative-based fractions must not be sold as shares.
- A low price doesn't fix hesitation: UK investors took 3.5 months on average to start, and 8% over a year.

RO/EU lens: Fractions are available in Romania (XTB, Revolut), but there is no Romanian data on round-ups or first-time investors; the only local survey is not representative.

Why it matters: The price barrier is falling; the fear of the first 'buy' is not, and that is the open design space.

Sources: 12 sources, short research, in the Research document